

Day 3 — Self-Observation: Your Tendencies

Module: Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students explain the distinction between *prakṛti* (constitutional baseline) and *vikṛti* (current state), complete a non-diagnostic self-observation worksheet, and articulate why the framework should be held lightly.

Materials

- Printed self-observation worksheet (one per student)
- The Caraka safety paraphrase on a slide or the board
- Sticky notes for the exit reflection

Vocabulary introduced today

- *prakṛti* (IAST: pra-kṛti; lit. “nature, primary disposition”) — in Ayurveda, the constitutional baseline you are born with: a particular *proportion* of *vāta* : *pitta* : *kapha*.
- *vikṛti* (IAST: vi-kṛti; lit. “deviation, modification”) — your *current* state. Can drift from *prakṛti* due to season, food, stress, sleep.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily prompt: “*What did your body notice yesterday?*” — 2 students share.
- “*Yesterday we learned the three doṣas in detail. Today we ask: which one tends to be loudest in you? Carefully.*”

Core (15 min)

1. **The *prakṛti* vs *vikṛti* distinction — write the analogy on the board.**

Think of yourself like a song. *Prakṛti* is the **key** — the underlying note your life is set in. *Vikṛti* is **today’s notes** — what you’re actually playing right now. The same song can be played calmly or frantically. The key doesn’t change. The notes do.

2. **Two things this distinction does:**

- It prevents the “I AM *vāta*” trap. You’re not a *doṣa*. You have a *tendency*.
- It explains why “you have a cold today” doesn’t change your constitution — it changes your *vikṛti*.

3. **Most people are dual-dominant.** Pure single-*doṣa prakṛti* is rare. Most people are *vāta-pitta*, *pitta-kapha*, or *vāta-kapha*. A few are roughly balanced across all three (*sama-prakṛti* — rarest).

4. **Source paraphrase.** “Classical Ayurveda holds that prakṛti is set at conception by the relative balance of the doṣas at that time, with influences from the mother’s diet and lifestyle during pregnancy.” (Paraphrased from Caraka Saṁhitā, Vimānasthāna 8 — discussed in fuller detail at Senior band.)

5. **The safety statement** (read aloud, every student copies into notebook):

This worksheet is for noticing, not diagnosis. I am not “a Vāta” or “a Pitta.” I have tendencies. If I have a medical concern, I will see a doctor — not my notebook.

Activity (20 min) — Self-observation worksheet

Hand out the worksheet (template below). Students fill it in privately. They are **not** asked to share the results.

Worksheet

My doṣa tendencies — a non-diagnostic self-observation

For each row, tick the column that best matches your usual self over the past month. There are no right answers. Be honest, not aspirational.

#	Question	Vāta	Pitta	Kapha
1	Build	thin, hard to gain weight	medium, athletic	solid, gains weight easily
2	Skin in winter	dry, cracks	sensitive, can flush	smooth, oily, cool
3	Energy through the day	bursty: high then low	steady-strong	slow-warm-up, long-lasting
4	Speech	fast, jumpy	clear, sharp	slow, measured
5	Appetite	irregular, sometimes forget meals	strong, must-eat-on-time	mild, can skip a meal easily
6	Sleep	light, dreams a lot	sound, ~7 hours, vivid dreams	deep, ~8+ hours, slow to wake
7	When stressed	worried, can’t settle	irritable, sharp-tongued	withdraw, eat or sleep
8	Hands	cold, sometimes dry	warm, sometimes moist	cool, sometimes oily
9	Movement	quick, restless	brisk, purposeful	steady, slow to start
10	Memory	quick to learn, quick to forget	sharp; remembers facts	slow to learn, never forgets

Total ticks per column: Vāta ____ Pitta ____ Kapha ____

My tentative tendency (not type!) is: _____

Important. No question has a “wrong” answer. Most people score across all three. The top column is your *current tendency* — which may or may not be your *prakṛti*.

Reminder: if I have a medical concern, I see a doctor — not this worksheet.

After completion (10 min), discussion (10 min):

- “Show of hands — who came out roughly balanced across two of the three?” Most.
- “Who came out heavily one-sided?” Some.
- “Now the important question — does today’s tendency match your usual? Or are you currently in a *vikṛti* state — recently slept poorly, eaten different food, exam stress?”

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Formative quiz on a slip of paper (5 questions, 3 min)** — see quizzes/formative.md Part A.
- Collect.
- Preview Day 4: “Tomorrow — sort 30 qualities into three buckets in a hands-on game.”

Student-facing content

Two important words:

- ***prakṛti*** = your baseline — the proportion of *vāta* : *pitta* : *kapha* you are born with.
- ***vikṛti*** = your current state — which can drift due to season, food, stress, sleep.

If you scored high on a column on the worksheet today, that’s your *current tendency*. It may or may not be your *prakṛti*. People shift around. That’s normal.

You are not a doṣa. You have a tendency. The framework is a lens, not a label.

Homework

- Keep the worksheet in your notebook. Tonight, redo it in your head AS IF it were yesterday morning. Did your top column shift? Note in one line.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Try the worksheet from your most calm week of the year vs your most stressed week. Compare. What does that tell you about *prakṛti* vs *vikṛti*?
- **One tier down:** Just complete the worksheet. The *prakṛti/vikṛti* distinction can be revisited on Day 5.

Teacher notes

- This is the most ethically sensitive day in the module. Watch for:
 - Students writing “I am Vāta” or “I am stupid because Kapha is slow” — interrupt these gently.
 - Students who score heavily on one column and seem distressed — pull aside privately.
 - Students who refuse to complete the worksheet — accept, no questions asked.
- **Do NOT collect or grade** the worksheets. They stay in the student’s notebook, private.

- The formative quiz is on the *framework concepts* — not on the worksheet’s content.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Caraka Saṃhitā, *Vimānasthāna* 8 (paraphrase on *prakṛti* determination). The full classical determination criteria are discussed at Senior band; here we paraphrase one principle.